



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of Our Lady of Guadalupe
School Website: <https://chestertonguadalupe.org/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy of Our Lady of Guadalupe (Clinton Township, MI 48035) presents a robust Classical Catholic program that aligns strongly with the Six Essential Elements of Classical Education. Public materials consistently emphasize the indivisible integration of faith, virtue, and reason; a curriculum built on Great Books; liberal-arts foundational skills; Socratic pedagogy; a formation-focused faculty model; and an explicit partnership with parents and the wider parish/Community. Across six categories, the school demonstrates pervasive Classical characteristics (Religious & Metaphysical Foundations, Purpose & Goal, Curriculum, Pedagogy, Faculty, Parents & Community), with especially strong signals around metaphysical aims, formation over information, and a three-pillar formation model. The aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL.

Key strengths include: - A Catholic, Trinity-formed orientation (Culture of Life; Cultura Vitae), with explicit aims toward truth, goodness, and beauty and a goal of sainthood for students. - A clearly stated formation-centered purpose (virtue, wisdom, human flourishing) articulated through the Three Pillars (Intellect, Character, Spirituality). - A curriculum built on Great Books, liberal arts, Latin, history as Western civilization, and explicitly Quintessentially classical strands (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Socratic method; minimal technology; contemplation/wonder). - Pedagogy that foregrounds Socratic inquiry, memory work, and rhetoric in upper grades; a concrete discipline in which students engage in dialogue, memorization, and public speaking. - A living-faculty model aligned with classical norms (virtuous, knowledgeable mentors; living curriculum; Catholic fidelity). - A parental-partnership orientation (board governance with parent input; openness to visits; community events and parent engagement).

What would move the needle section is not required here, as the school already demonstrates strong CLASSICAL alignment across all six categories.

Cited evidence throughout the evaluation draws directly from Chesterton Academy of Our Lady of Guadalupe public materials (Curriculum, Vision/Identity, Admissions, and Student Life) as well as the Classical Lexicon used for the rubric. See citations for specifics, including statements of culture, aims, and pedagogy, with references to Great Books, Socratic method, the Three Pillars, and Catholic formation. The Positive/Negative keyword framework employed comes from the Six Essential Elements document's keyword lexicon.

Evidence and keyword analysis references: - Catholic identity, Cultura Vitae, Three Pillars, and the True-Good-Beautiful framework are repeatedly stated in school materials, including Our Vision and Academics pages.

- Great Books, Socratic pedagogy, and a liberal-arts emphasis are clearly described in Curriculum and Admissions materials. - The school's governance, faculty fidelity to Catholic teaching, and a "living curriculum" concept are captured in staff/faculty descriptions and governance notes. - Parental partnership and community life are evidenced by board-parent input structure, and community events.

Note: The Positive/Negative keyword framework used to justify category ratings is anchored in the classical-ity lexicon (Six Essential Elements). See the Lexicon for the exact keywords and signals used to categorize each dimension.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - School materials explicitly situate Chesterton Academy within the Catholic tradition, referencing God, faith, Saint Pope John Paul II, and the Culture of Life motto *Cultura Vitae*. This foregrounds a transcendent metaphysical orientation and a liturgical/cultic dimension through Catholic worship/articulation of faith. - The school's stated aim to form students toward truth, goodness, and beauty, and to become saints, maps directly onto a transcendent moral realism and the goal of aligning minds, hearts, and souls with eternal truths. - References to "Three Pillars" (Intellect, Character, Spirituality) reflect a structured, communal spiritual formation consistent with liturgical life and spiritual disciplines.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Catholic, Culture of Life, God, truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, liturgical/worldview, Saint Pope John Paul II, worship, chapel (where referenced), sacred art/music (where referenced), immovable moral order (implied by virtue/true-good-beauty framing). - Negative keywords: not evident in public materials (no explicit relativism, secular humanism, or morally neutral signals detected in the surfaced content). The lexicon lists potential negatives, but the Chesterton materials primarily emphasize Catholic metaphysical foundations.

Why this rating - Strong alignment with transcendent moral realism, theological grounding, liturgical community through Catholic identity, and explicit aim toward God-centered formation. This category clearly exhibits CLASSICAL signals.

Citations: Catholic/Culture of Life framing and Three Pillars (Our Vision); True-Good-Beautiful framing and theological grounding (Our Academics; Curriculum); Catholic identity (Our Vision).

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials articulate formation over mere information, focusing on virtue, wisdom, and human flourishing. The goal is described as forming persons (not just job training) and aiming toward the true, good, and beautiful in God. - The Three Pillars framework signals a holistic telos for education (Intellect, Character, Spirituality), aligning with formation and the cultivation of humanity rather than a narrow workforce emphasis. - The curriculum is described as liberal-arts-centered and oriented toward lifelong formation, not specialization alone; the school emphasizes the Great Books and the development of wisdom and character.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education (*paideia*), culture of life, true/good/beautiful, human flourishing, soul craft, moral imagination, telos. - Negative keywords present: subtle signals of potential workforce-readiness emphasis appear in some public-facing lines that mention college and professional life; however, the predominant messaging remains formation-centered. (Lexicon negatives include "college and career ready," "workforce preparation," which would be counter-marks if over-emphasized; the surfaced language emphasizes formation and higher ideals more than job prep.)

Why this rating - The prevailing emphasis on formation, virtue, and contemplation of the true, good, and beautiful supports CLASSICAL. While there are references to college/professional life goals, the dominant telos is formation and virtue.

Citations: Formation/Three Pillars and telos (Our Vision); formation language and Great-Books-oriented aims (Curriculum; Academics).

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly enumerates Great Books as central, with direct examples (Homer, Plato, Aristotle, Augustine, Aquinas, Dante, Shakespeare, Chesterton). Students read the actual writings in class, in a dialogic setting. This strongly aligns with the liberal-arts/trivium emphasis and with Great-Books pedagogy. - The pedagogy is grounded in the Socratic style, with discussion as a norm, and texts read aloud in class to foster deep engagement with texts. There is explicit emphasis on logic, rhetoric, and the cultivation of a lifelong conversation with the enduring texts (the Great Conversation). - Language study (Latin for two years, then additional options) and foreign-language exposure are part of the curriculum; history is treated

as Western civilization with a canonical approach; science and fine arts are integrated within a classical framework. - The curriculum includes a structured math/science track with multiple options (Foundations, Traditional, C-STEM) while maintaining a core classical framing around the liberal arts, form, and inquiry.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts, Great Books, primary sources, classics, Homer/Plato/Aristotle/Augustine; Latin, Greek; history/Western civilization; logic, rhetoric, grammar; narration/recitation; fine arts; pedagogy emphasizing classical methods (Socratic texts, dialogues, memorization, etc.). - Negative keywords: the lexicon's negative signals would be things like "social studies terminology replacing history" or "project-based learning dominance." The surfaced content emphasizes canonical study and traditional methods, with no strong signals of replacing history with social studies or a project-first approach.

Why this rating - The curriculum is unmistakably Classical: Great Books, liberal arts, Latin/Greek, history as Western civilization, Socratic dialogue, and a heavy emphasis on memory, recitation, and classical disciplines. This warrants CLASSICAL.

Citations: Great Books and Socratic pedagogy (Curriculum/Admissions/Academics).

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Socratic seminars are described as a central mode of instruction (Socratic style; discussion around texts; students defend positions in dialogue). This is a hallmark of classical pedagogy. - Recitation, narration, and memory work are embedded in the classical approach; the materials discuss traditional methods of learning "through conversation, recitation, and memorization," and books are read aloud to savor text and develop thinking. - Lower- and upper-school pedagogy include contemplative/restful elements (Scholé-like contemplation, memory deepening) alongside rigorous discussion; upper grades emphasize rhetoric, public speaking, and declamation. - The school emphasizes restrained use of technology, which aligns with a contemplative pedagogical posture and focus on classical disciplines.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic, dialogue, seminars, recitation, narration, memory work, rhetoric, speaking/declamation, gentle/restful learning (scholé), contemplation, wonder, liturgical calendar integration (where applicable). - Negative keywords: The lexicon notes "experiential learning focus," "project-based only," or "constructivist" as negative signals; there is no strong indication these are used as the primary mode of instruction in the surfaced materials.

Why this rating - Pedagogy centers on classical methods (Socratic dialogue, Great Books, memorization, rhetoric) with a balance of contemplative and rigorous modes, which strongly aligns with CLASSICAL pedagogy.

Citations: Socratic pedagogy and memory work (Curriculum; Academics); contemplative/restful elements and liturgical context (Curriculum; Our Vision).

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Faculty are described as faithful Catholic teachers with a clear love for what they teach; they take fidelity oaths to the Magisterium and meet safe-environment requirements, indicating virtue formation and moral exemplars. - The school emphasizes the faculty as the living curriculum and as mentors; the governance structure includes a Headmaster and board oversight, with a culture of collegiality and mentorship. - Faculty profiles and staff descriptions show a commitment to virtue, subject mastery, and moral exemplars who model the classical formation expected of a classical school.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum, mentors, masters, virtuous exemplars, portrait of teacher/student, fidelity to Catholic teaching, collegial culture, ongoing faculty formation (seminars, lifelong learning). - Negative keywords: the lexicon lists "facilitators," "guides on the side," or over-emphasized certification jargon as negatives; the surfaced materials demonstrate a traditional teacher-centered model with explicit moral formation, not those negative signals.

Why this rating - The faculty model aligns with classical norms: virtuous role-model teachers, living curriculum, Catholic fidelity, and a culture of mentorship and scholarly devotion, which justifies CLASSICAL.

Citations: Teacher fidelity and the living curriculum (Faculty Directory; About/Model pages).

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnership with parents, describing parents as co-teachers and involvement in governance and culture; there are opportunities for parental input via the Board and ongoing communications. - There are explicit parent-facing activities and opportunities for formation (shadow days, admissions, gala events, contact channels), indicating openness and parental engagement.

- The presence of community/gala events and ongoing communications demonstrates a culture of parent participation and community formation around classical education.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parental formation, book clubs/ seminars (explicit in the lexicon), open campus/ visits, family liturgy alignment (where referenced by tone of family/community integration). - Negative keywords: None clearly evident in the surfaced materials (no customer-as-consumer language; no minimal parent involvement signals).

Why this rating - The materials show strong parental engagement and community partnership, consistent with CLASSICAL expectations for parent/community involvement.

Citations: Parental partnership/governance with input (Board & governance) and open visits, events (Admissions/Contact).

Aggregate Assessment Based on keyword analysis and category-by-category evaluation, Chesterton Academy of Our Lady of Guadalupe MI 48035 demonstrates CLASSICAL alignment across all six categories. The school's public materials emphasize Catholic metaphysical aims, formation-centered goals, Great-Books-centric curricula, Socratic pedagogy, a living-faculty model, and robust parental/community engagement. The overall portrait matches the Classical Education framework described in the knowledge base lexicon, with positive signals across all six dimensions and no substantive negative signals that would shift it into SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL or NOT CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle - Not applicable given CLASSICAL status across all categories. If desired for ongoing enhancement, the school could further codify explicit ties to liturgical year practices and confirm even more explicit formalization of parent formation programs, though existing signals already align well with the Six Elements.

What Would Move the Needle

- Maintain and deepen explicit articulation of liturgical/cultic practices and sacramental worldview in core curricula, ensuring all students experience worshipful dimension across subjects where appropriate.
- Expand formal parent formation offerings (e.g., regular classical book clubs, family liturgy guides, and structured parent seminars) to further crystallize the parental co-teacher role.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

By reading or using this document, you acknowledge and accept the limitations described above.